

The Order Theory of Interaction

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An inquiry into Developmental Psychology

Man can only be himself when he accepts
and transcends himself.

- Yat

'Definition'

Interaction is the generalized participation into and identification of the processes, structures and phenomena of any entity (living or non-living) with the human organism involved, in which knowledge, experiences and emotional responses are elicited or emitted. At the interpersonal level, interactions are the dynamic processes by which human experiences and emotions are communicated and transacted. In any intimate human relations, a high affect field is usually developed; it induces a group of emotional activities in the participators concerned.

'Terminology and Nomenclature of Interaction'

Degree - the degree of an interaction is the number of participants in the interaction.

It may range from menadic to pluralistic (n-adic).

Order - the order of an interaction is the modality of the interaction. Zeroth-order interaction is the undifferentiated instinctual interaction with objects in the physical Universe. First-order interaction represents nearly all acquired or learned behaviours through conditioning or reinforcement. Second-order interaction refers to interactions through affect fields, in which emotions are displayed. Third-order interaction is characterized by the manipulation of an abstract, symbolic language system. Higher-order interactions will be increasingly abstract and complex.

Rank - the rank of an interaction is the depth or intimacy of ontological participation into the interaction. Thus, a first-rank interaction is the deepest or the most intimate one, and the depth or intimacy decreases with higher ranks.

'Theory of Personality'

The personality of a human organism is his experiential and emotional structures, determined both genetically and environmentally. At its best, personality is open to change through experiences or therapy. I suspect that there is no absolute criterion for studying personality for it is so mutable that it may be merely the vogue of the times. Besides, the matrix of personality is multi-dimensional - there are pluralistic and

interwoven determinants of personality, rather than a singular one.

'Towards a synthetic theory of personality'

Core of personality:

Core tendencies - to maintain the homeostasis of the biological system through the pursuit and gratification of basic survival needs and instinctual impulses; to establish ego-identity through love and actualization of the inherent and acquired potentialities, if conditions of development are optimum.

Core structure - there are different core structures appropriate to the stages of development. These structures undergo evolution with changes in qualities as the growth of personality proceeds.

Development and growth with special reference to the Order Theory of Interaction

Developmental Stages

Infantile Stage - Human beings are born helpless and need love and nurture unconditionally to sustain life. Zeroth-order interaction is the primary mode of experiencing the world (Prototaxis); there is no sense of ego-boundary. Birth is a process of alienation and the infant is susceptible to the existential anxiety innate to separation. Orality characterizes this stage and the mouth remains one of the erogenous zone in life. Body contact between the infant and the mothering one serves to provide warmth and ontological security for him, as well as to help him to explore the boundary and sensations of his body. Imprinting of maternal figure occurs in this period. Display of emotions through facial expressions is learned. First-order interaction with the environment gradually develops with parataxic mode of experiencing. Loss of love and nurture, or the threat of loss of them will induce intense anxiety or somnolent detachment of the infant.

Childhood

- Socialization begins in which the major dimensions of the culture are learned through conditioning and reinforcement. Affect or emotional responses are usually associated with such learnings. The mode of transaction develops almost exponentially; second and third-order interactions become increasingly dominant. Language starts to be the most important tool of communication (Syntaxis). Several important groups of emotions are internalized in the rudimentary self-system, including guilt, aggressiveness and dissociation.

Juvenile Stage - This stage is characterized by the ability to manipulate abstract concepts through symbolic representations. Third-order interaction prevails with syntactic mode of experiencing. Social interactions are experimented and practised through identifications and consensus. The need of compeers makes him participate in group activities. Friendship is more valued and intimate relationship can be formed, in general, with a member of the same sex. Individual differences can be perceived.

Adolescent Stage - this stage is characterized by the need to establish ego-identity through love, interpersonal intimacy and the actualization of the inherent potentialities. Stable patterns of satisfying the sexual desire with a member of the opposite sex are developed. Ideals are erected to give him a meaning of life.

Periphery of personality

In real life, nearly every person exhibits a syndrome of the developmental stages. The dominant traits or stages are largely the determinants of the past experiences and the socio-economic and cultural backgrounds of the individual concerned. Intrapsychic conflict is a necessary but not sufficient condition for personality development; objective conditions must be optimum enough for it. When an individual is hurled into the ladder of development, he has to relinquish the ontological security and participation pertaining to that particular stage. Consequently, it is not surprising that the individual always possesses remnants of his earlier stages of development. Moreover, psychological development is not irreversible; the individual may show regression to his earlier stages under stress and intrapsychic conflict. Maturity, if any, is situational and specific, rather than absolute and all-encompassing. Human beings are not at all so strong.

Personality types:

The integrated character type - it represents an ideal in the real world and can only be attained rarely. A person having this character type has an integrated self system - his experiential structure is open completely and objectively to his external world; his emotional structure is stable and rich, capable of giving unconditionally. Multi-order interactions dominate his transactions with himself, other persons and his world, in which the self and the body are the phenomenological Gestalt. He has an established ego-identity.

Autonomy and communion are the dialectical (complementary but simultaneous) poles of his self-system. He has empathy and is able to share emotions and experiences with others, but can detach himself from his perspective and subjective beliefs and assume other perspectives to observe and perceive the world. He is aware of his limitations but is willing to accept and transcend them; he can actualize his inherent potentialities through creativity and independence.

The shattered character type - We are all, at times, with this character type; it consists of a wide spectrum or syndrome of fixations and deviations in the developmental stages, with high skew-order interactions. A system of defence mechanism, or even false selves is employed to avoid anxieties and unresolved emotional complexes. Classical methods of defence include projection, denial, distortion, introjection, intellectualization, reaction formation, isolation, undoing, repression and sublimation. Persons of this type are susceptible to paranoid development and tend to judge people as stereotypes with very critical standard.

'Religions and ideologies vis-a-vis developmental psychology'

Many great religions and ideologies have their appeal in the mass for they can satisfy the emotional needs of the regressive fixations and syndrome in the developmental stages of human beings. Thus, the whole nation and even the whole age, can become the prey of mass psychosis, of which the Dark Ages and the Nazi Germany are the best examples. At this level, personality, or even truth is but the mere vogue of the ages. The world turns topsy-turvy and the past history and endeavour of the people in it are futile. In particular, value judgement in studying personality is arbitrary. There exists an immense difference between the concepts of maturity and ethics in the Oriental and the Occidental worlds, although cross-cultural influences begin to exert a profound impact on such issues.

'The order-theory of interactions and the world'

Social institutions in our world are largely structures derived and developed from human interactions. A social institution is a complex structure in which variable-rank variable-degree and variable-order interactions are transacted between a group of human beings. Thus, modern family can be viewed as the structural institution in which first-rank dyadic multi-order interactions are transacted between the pair bond (if they love each other). In general, the rank, degree and order of a social institution depend on the environment and the initial conditions, for example, the form of the institution of the family has many variants such as monogamy, polyandry, polygyny and group marriage.

In epistemology, science is the abstractions and constructs of n-adic third-order interactions derived from lower-order interactions with the phenomena and processes of the Universe. Thus, interactions with the physical world produce the various branches of natural science; while interactions with the human world bring forth social sciences. The pursuit of arts can be viewed as the expression of second-order interactions through language or actions. Philosophy and religion attempt to unify all orders of interactions with the world.

'Alienation and Communion and the boundary conditions of personality'

Alienation is the golden path to theories; communion is the watchword of praxis. They are indivisible. And conflict is the key to human development. Ours is a history of separation and reunion; born naked and unwillingly into this meaningless world, man has to experience this primary existential anxiety inherent to his extrauterine life, before which he is but a fetus inside his mother's womb, absolutely dependent on her. After birth, he is hurled into a hostile and unfamiliar world, he has alienated from his mother. Endowed with the unique gift of self-awareness, and grasped in his development, man can, at least, in imagination, isolate himself from his objective reality and even from himself. He has to be independent and autonomous; he also has to face his freedom and responsibility. He is well aware of the fact that he is an agent by himself and that he is separated from his physical environment and other persons. Yet, this form of alienation also makes him the crown of evolution, the king of the biological world. It helps him to develop inquiries into his world and derive knowledge from them. As, to this extent, boundary conditions for personality exist and are but the dialectical processes of alienation and communion.

Communion is the merging of oneself with any entity (living or non-living) in the world or in imagination. The so-called religious feeling and the transcendental states are the manifestation of communion. They involve interactions beyond (before) the zeroth-order and can be expressed in sexuality and mystical love. It seems that communion has some connections with second-order interactions. Religions and ideologies are, in fact, the human products of this tendency, as an escape from the primary existential anxiety. However, such traditional religions and ideologies are futile, for the answer lies in ourselves: we should seek communion through interpersonal transactions. In action, we should participate as the Gestalt. (Persons of integrated character type usually have well-developed poles of alienation and communion.)

'Therapy and change'

Being eclectic is perhaps the best approach to social science, so to psychology and psychotherapy. Different kinds of therapy are appropriate to different sub-character types or pathological disorders. Classical psychoanalysis brings out the unconscious motives and impulses to the cognitive field of the client through transference and helps him to cope with them. Behavioural therapy such as systematic desensitization can combat against phobias and undesirable habits. Regerian therapy will probably cure schizophrenics and chronic psychotics. The therapeutic method and process can be highly flexible, depending on the conditions and development of the client. It is extremely difficult to have any predictions of the future of the field of personality study and psychotherapy. We should wait and see how human beings develop.